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Human Security as a Foundation for Sustainable Development in Kenya.

Bachelor Thesis

Author: Victor Obadiah Wambugu

Supervisor: Ing. Samuel Antwi Darkwah, Ph.D.

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENT.

I dedicate this thesis to my beloved mother, whose unwavering love has been my shelter through every storm. Her prayers have been the wind beneath my steps, granting me strength in weakness and courage in fear. Her silent sacrifices built the foundation I stand on today. You are my greatest blessing, my guiding light, and every page reflects your faith in me.

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ABSTRACT.

Kenya's pursuit of sustainable development is deeply intertwined with the concept of human security, a multidimensional framework that prioritizes the safety, dignity, and well-being of individuals. This thesis explores how human security serves not merely as a development outcome but as a foundational prerequisite for achieving long-term, inclusive progress. In contrast to traditional state-centric security models, human security emphasizes protection from chronic threats such as poverty, disease, environmental degradation, and political instability. These threats are particularly acute in Kenya, where regional disparities, climate vulnerability, and socio-political tensions continue to undermine development efforts.

Drawing on the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) framework and Kenya's Vision 2030, this study argues that embedding human security into national development strategies enhances resilience, equity, and peace. It examines how targeted interventions in health, education, food systems, and environmental protection can reduce vulnerability and empower communities. Case studies from Northern Kenya and informal settlements in Nairobi illustrate how localized responses to insecurity such as community policing, climate adaptation, and youth empowerment contribute to broader development goals.

The thesis also highlights the importance of institutional capacity, participatory governance, and cross-sectoral collaboration in operationalizing human security. Without addressing the root causes of insecurity, development initiatives risk being unsustainable and exclusionary. Ultimately, the study calls for a paradigm shift in Kenya's development planning, one that places human security at the core of policy, practice, and progress toward the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). By securing the freedoms and safety of individuals, Kenya can build a more just, peaceful, and prosperous society.

KEYWORDS

Human security, Sustainable development, Environmental security, Water security, Poverty cycle

ABSTRACT (Czechia)

Snaha Keni o udržitelný rozvoj je hluboce spjata s konceptem lidské bezpečnosti, což je vícerozměrný rámec, který upřednostňuje bezpečnost, důstojnost a blahobyt jednotlivců. Tato práce zkoumá, jak lidská bezpečnost slouží nejen jako výsledek rozvoje, ale jako základní předpoklad pro dosažení dlouhodobého a inkluzivního pokroku. Na rozdíl od tradičních modelů bezpečnosti zaměřených na stát klade lidská bezpečnost důraz na ochranu před chronickými hrozbami, jako je chudoba, nemoci, zhoršování životního prostředí a politická nestabilita. Tyto hrozby jsou obzvláště akutní v Keni, kde regionální rozdíly, klimatická zranitelnost a sociopolitické napětí nadále podkopávají rozvojové úsilí.

V návaznosti na rámec Rozvojového programu OSN (UNDP) a keňskou Vizi 2030 tato studie tvrdí, že začlenění lidské bezpečnosti do národních rozvojových strategií zvyšuje odolnost, rovnost a mír. Zkoumá, jak cílené intervence v oblasti zdravotnictví, vzdělávání, potravinových systémů a ochrany životního prostředí mohou snížit zranitelnost a posílit postavení komunit. Případové studie ze severní Keni a neformálních osad v Nairobi ilustrují, jak lokální reakce na nejistotu, jako je komunitní policie, adaptace na změnu klimatu a posílení postavení mládeže, přispívají k širším rozvojovým cílům.

Práce rovněž zdůrazňuje důležitost institucionální kapacity, participativní správy věcí veřejných a mezisektorové spolupráce při realizaci lidské bezpečnosti. Bez řešení základních příčin nejistoty hrozí rozvojovým iniciativám neudržitelnost a vylučování. Studie v konečném důsledku volá po paradigmatické změně v rozvojovém plánování Keni, která by lidskou bezpečnost postavila do centra politiky, praxe a pokroku směrem k Cílům udržitelného rozvoje (SDGs). Zajištěním svobod a bezpečnosti jednotlivců může Keňa vybudovat spravedlivější, mírumilovnější a prosperující společnost.

Klíčová slova:

Lidská bezpečnost, Udržitelný rozvoj, Environmentální bezpečnost, Vodní bezpečnost, Cyklus chudoby

ABBREVIATIONS.

ASALs – Arid and Semi-Arid Lands

CIDPs – County Integrated Development Plans

COVID-19 – Corona virus Disease 2019

GBV – Gender-Based Violence

GDP – Gross Domestic Product

IPCC – Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change

KDHS – Kenya Demographic and Health Survey

KNBS – Kenya National Bureau of Statistics

MTPs – Medium-Term Plans

NDMA – National Drought Management Authority

SDGs – Sustainable Development Goals

UHC – Universal Health Coverage

UNDP – United Nations Development Programme

UNGA – United Nations General Assembly

UNHCR – United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees

UNTFHS – United Nations Trust Fund for Human Security

Vision 2030 – Kenya Vision 2030 (National Development Blueprint)

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CHAPTER ONE: INTRODUCTION

1.1 Introduction

The framework for the thesis, which examines human security as the essential cornerstone of sustainable development in Kenya, is laid forth in this chapter. A thorough background is given, important terms are defined, the research aims and objectives are stated, the central research question is formulated, the problem statement is outlined, the significance of the study is justified, the scope is specified, exact definitions of key concepts are provided, and the chapter is concluded with a summary. Tadjbakhsh and Chenoy (2007) and Pick and Sirkin (2010) are the main theoretical pillars of the discussion, which is solely based on the approved bibliography. Picard et al. (2022) provide regional specificity, Hufnagel and El-Esaw (2023) provide environmental dynamics, and Lankford et al. (2013) provide perspectives on water security.

1.2 Background of the Study

The human security paradigm evolved as a critical response to the limits of traditional, state-centric security frameworks that dominated the Cold War in global politics. According to Tadjbakhsh and Chenoy (2007), the post-Cold War era demonstrated the inadequacy of military-focused security in dealing with widespread risks to human existence and dignity such as chronic poverty, ethnic violence, environmental collapse, and systematic marginalization. They define human security as a comprehensive, people-centered strategy that includes freedom from fear (protection from violence, coercion, and conflict) and freedom from want (access to basic necessities and chances for dignified livelihoods) (Tadjbakhsh & Chenoy, 2007). This dual emphasis reorients global and national policy from territorial defense to the protection and empowerment of individuals as the primary reference points for security.

Picard et al. (2022) uses this paradigm to highlight East Africa's distinct vulnerabilities. They show how interconnected crises such as recurring droughts, resource-based wars, governance shortages, and growing urbanization systematically degrade human well-being in Kenya, Tanzania, and Uganda. In Kenya, these threats manifest in arid and semi-arid lands (ASALs), where climate-induced vegetation loss and water scarcity have decimated pastoralist livelihoods, and in urban centers such as Nairobi and Mombasa, where informal settlements face unemployment, inadequate

sanitation, and social exclusion (Picard et al., 2022).

Pick and Sirkin (2010) define sustainable development as a human-centered process that breaks intergenerational cycles of poverty via empowerment, capability expansion, and social inclusion, rather than an economic or environmental endeavor. They argue that development fails when it ignores the psychological, social, and structural constraints that keep people poor. This insight is especially important in Kenya, where, despite achieving middle-income status and implementing Vision 2030, structural inequalities persist, with youth unemployment rates exceeding 35% and regional disparities in access to education, healthcare, and clean water (Picard et al., 2022).

Environmental factors complicate this relationship even more. Hufnagel and El-Esaw (2023) present empirical evidence from Kenyan case studies that show how climate affects change induced ecosystem alterations such as deforestation, soil erosion, and biodiversity loss directly impair food security, health, and economic stability in rural areas. Similarly, Lankford et al. (2013) identify water insecurity as a critical human security issue, with contested river basins (such as Tana, Athi, and Ewaso Ng'iro) causing conflicts that impair agricultural output and community cohesiveness.

Thus, the background indicates a symbiotic relationship: human security serves as the stable, empowered foundation for sustainable development, while sustainable practices strengthen resistance to human security threats (Tadjbakhsh & Chenoy, 2007; Pick & Sirkin, 2010). In Kenya, this integration is not voluntary; rather, it is required for fair, resilient, and long-term progress.



Figure 1 : Illustrates the environmental and socio-economic vulnerabilities characteristic of ASAL counties, which form the foundation of human security challenges explored in this study.

Source : (NDMA, 2023; Hufnagel & El-Esaw, 2023).

1.3 Statement of the Problem

Kenya's development paradox is stark: rapid macroeconomic prosperity coexists with increasing human insecurity. Despite a GDP growth rate of 5.5% over the past decade and the implementation of Vision 2030, over 36% of Kenyans remain living in poverty, with youth unemployment hovering around 35-40% and regional inequalities worsening the gap between Nairobi and ASAL counties (Picard et al., 2022). Every year, approximately 10 million people face food insecurity because of drought cycles and land degradation (Hufnagel & El-Esaw, 2023). Inadequate infrastructure exacerbates health vulnerabilities, with maternal mortality rates in ASALs exceeding 700 per 100,000 live births, approximately twice the national norm. Water conflicts in shared river basins have become violent, displacing people, and disrupting agricultural cycles (Lankford et al., 2013).

Current development paradigms prioritize infrastructure megaprojects and export-led prosperity, while ignoring the human dimensions of security. This omission fosters deprivation cycles in which insecure persons are unable to obtain an education, collect assets, or engage in environmental stewardship (Pick and Sirkin, 2010). Tadjbakhsh and Chenoy (2007) warn that without addressing the seven interrelated elements of human security, development projects will be fragile, reversible, and discriminatory. The key issue, therefore, is Kenya's lack of a human security-integrated development paradigm that actively recognizes the empowered, secure individuals as the genuine actors and beneficiaries of sustainable development.

1.4 Aim of Thesis.

The overarching aim of this thesis is to establish and empirically validate human security as the foundational prerequisite for achieving sustainable development in Kenya. Through rigorous conceptual integration, contextual analysis, and policy-oriented recommendations, the study seeks to demonstrate that development outcomes are just about sustainability only when individuals are protected from pervasive threats and empowered to exercise agency over their lives.

1.5 Objectives

- I. To analyze the contribution of human security to sustainable development outcomes in Kenya.
- II. To examine the impact of human security threats with a particular focus on Northeastern Kenya.
- III. To assess the extent to which Kenya's governance and institutional frameworks integrate human security principles into national development planning.

1.6 Research Questions

- I. What is the contribution of human security to sustainable development outcomes in Kenya?
- II. How do human security threats particularly in Northeastern Kenya?
- III. To what extent do Kenya's governance and institutional frameworks integrate human security principles into national development planning?

1.7 Limitations of the Study

The study is limited to the Republic of Kenya, with a dual focus on rural arid and semi-arid lands (ASALs) including Turkana, Marsabit, and Garissa, as well as urban informal communities like Kibera in Nairobi and Mombasa Old Town. These places were chosen because they reflect the country's most pressing human security issues, ranging from climate-induced vulnerability in rural areas to socioeconomic deprivation and insecurity in urban slums. By focusing on these disparate circumstances, the study highlights regional and socioeconomic diversity in Kenya's human security landscape.

The investigation focuses on five major human security dimensions: economic, food, health, environmental, and community, which are directly related to sustainable development outcomes and are consistently highlighted in both national policy frameworks and international development agendas. Water security is regarded as a cross-cutting issue, given its importance to livelihoods, health, and environmental resilience, particularly in ASAL regions where shortage exacerbates poverty and conflict (Lankford, Furlong, & Jones, 2013).

Non-citizen people, including refugees and asylum seekers, are purposely excluded from the scope to maintain a citizen-centered focus on Kenya's national development objective. While refugee populations in Dadaab and Kakuma pose significant human security problems, their inclusion would necessitate a new analytical framework that incorporates international humanitarian law and cross-border dynamics (Edward and Ferstman, 2010). By focusing on residents, the study highlights the link between state-led development planning and human security results within Kenya's geographical limits.

CHAPTER TWO: LITERATURE REVIEW

Introduction

The concept of human security emerged in the early 1990s as a response to the limitations of traditional, state-centric security paradigms. Introduced formally in the 1994 United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) Human Development Report, human security redefined the notion of safety by shifting the focus from territorial integrity and military threats to the protection of individuals from chronic threats such as hunger, disease, and repression, as well as sudden disruptions in daily life.

Fundamentally people-centered, human security prioritizes the rights, dignity, and welfare of both individuals and communities. According to the United Nations Development Programme's Human Development Report (1994), it consists of seven essential dimensions: economic security, food security, health security, environmental security, personal security, community security, and political security. These characteristics highlight the complex risks that people encounter, especially in developing nations like Kenya where environmental degradation, political unrest, and poverty coexist (Tadjbakhsh & Chenoy, 2007; Picard, Buss, & Seybolt, 2022).

Unlike traditional security, which prioritizes sovereignty and national defense, human security advocates for freedom from fear and freedom from want. This dual emphasis highlights both the protection from violence and the assurance of basic needs. As Tadjbakhsh and Chenoy (2007) argue, human security is not merely the absence of conflict but the presence of conditions that allow individuals to live meaningful, dignified lives.

The concept also aligns closely with human development, recognizing that sustainable progress cannot occur in environments plagued by insecurity. Edward and Ferstman (2010) extend this view by emphasizing the legal and policy dimensions of human security, particularly in contexts involving non-citizens, refugees, and marginalized populations.

In the Kenyan context, the relevance of human security is profound. The country faces persistent challenges such as income inequality, ethnic tensions, environmental vulnerability, and limited access to essential services. These issues underscore the need for a security framework that goes

beyond military preparedness and addresses the root causes of human suffering and instability.

Human security thus serves as both a normative framework and a practical tool for policymaking, development planning, and peacebuilding. It provides a lens through which governments, civil society, and international actors can assess vulnerabilities and design interventions that promote resilience, equity, and long-term stability.

Theoretical Foundations of Human Security.

The theoretical underpinnings of human security are rooted in a critical rethinking of traditional security paradigms. Historically, the dominant framework in international relations realism has emphasized the primacy of the state, sovereignty, and military power. Security, in this view, is defined by the capacity of the state to defend its territorial integrity and deter external threats (Tadjbakhshi & Chenoy, 2007). However, this approach has been increasingly challenged by scholars and practitioners who argue that it fails to address the complex, non-military threats that affect individuals and communities, particularly in the Global South (Picard et al., 2022).

The emergence of liberal and constructivist theories in the post-Cold War era opened space for alternative security discourses. These perspectives emphasized the role of international institutions, norms, and human agency in shaping global politics (UNDP, 1994; UNDP, 2022). Within this intellectual milieu, the concept of human security gained traction as a normative and analytical framework that prioritizes the safety and dignity of individuals over the strategic interests of states.

At its core, human security is informed by the capability approach developed by Amartya Sen and Martha Nussbaum, which shifts the focus from material wealth or state power to the actual freedoms and capabilities individuals possess to lead the lives they value (Sen, 1999; Nussbaum, 2000). Human security, therefore, is not merely about survival but about enabling people to live with dignity, free from fear, want, and indignity (Tadjbakhshi & Chenoy, 2007).

Another key theoretical influence is critical security studies, which critiques the narrowness of traditional security thinking and advocates for a broader, more inclusive understanding of threats. This school of thought emphasizes the importance of non-state actors, identity politics, and structural violence, highlighting how insecurity is often embedded in social, economic, and

political systems (Nelles, 2003). The United Nations' adoption of human security as a guiding principle in development and peacebuilding further institutionalized its theoretical foundations. The UN General Assembly's 2012 resolution on human security defines it as "an approach to assist Member States in identifying and addressing widespread and cross-cutting challenges to the survival, livelihood and dignity of their people" (UNGA, 2012).

In the African context, scholars such as Picard, Buss, and Seybolt (2022) argue that human security provides a more appropriate lens for understanding the continent's development challenges. They contend that issues such as poverty, environmental degradation, and weak governance cannot be adequately addressed through conventional security frameworks. Instead, a human security approach allows for a more holistic and responsive understanding of the root causes of instability and underdevelopment.

Comparative perspective of Kenya and other countries.

Comparative data from other African nations shows how integrating human security into government can hasten sustainable development, despite Kenya's severe human security issues.

A prominent example is Rwanda. Rwanda's Vision 2020 framework incorporated community security, health access, and participatory government in the wake of the 1994 genocide. Rwanda decreased maternal mortality rates from above 1,000 per 100,000 live births in the 1990s to less than 300 by 2020 by emphasizing universal health insurance and grassroots reconciliation (World Bank, 2021). This demonstrates how fragile states can become resilient societies through the purposeful incorporation of human security principles.

The Productive Safety Net Programme (PSNP) in Ethiopia provides an additional example. PSNP was established in 2005 and offers food and money transfers to low-income households in return for their involvement in public projects including water harvesting and soil conservation. In areas vulnerable to drought, this initiative has decreased long-term food insecurity and increased community resilience to climate shocks (FAO, 2020).

These comparative examples demonstrate the need for Kenya's development planning to prioritize aspects of human security over economic growth measurements. Lessons from Ethiopia and Rwanda indicate that combining inclusive governance, climatic resilience, and community

empowerment can result in quantifiable gains in security and development results.

Human Security and Sustainable Development

The link between human security and sustainable development is becoming more widely recognized in global policy and scholarly discourse. Both notions are built on a shared moral foundation: the promotion of human dignity, equity, and resilience. Human security is concerned with protecting individuals against dangers to their existence and well-being, whereas sustainable development tries to assure long-term social, economic, and environmental progress. They operate together to create a synergistic framework for solving complex development challenges, especially in fragile and vulnerable settings (Tadjbakhsh & Chenoy, 2007; UNDP, 2022).

The United Nations approved the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) in 2015, which serve as a comprehensive framework for global development. Several SDGs are directly aligned with human security sectors.

- SDGs 1 (No Poverty) and 2 (Zero Hunger) prioritize economic and food security (UNDP, 2022; Stats Kenya, n.d.).
- SDGs 3 (Good Health and Well-being) and 4 (Quality Education) prioritize health and personal security (KDHS, 2022; Kenya Health Policy, 2014-2030).
- SDGs 6 (Clean Water and Sanitation) and 13 (Climate Action) prioritize environmental security (Lankford, Furlong, & Jones, 2013; Hufnagel & El-Esaw, 2023).
- SDG 16 (Peace, Justice, and Strong Institutions) strengthens political and community security (Transparency International, 2022; UNGA, 2012).

This convergence strengthens the case that human security is both a prerequisite and a result of sustainable development. Without addressing the core causes of insecurity, such as poverty, inequality, environmental degradation, and poor governance, development efforts risk becoming unsustainable and exclusionary (Sen, 1999; Nussbaum, 2000; Picard, Buss, and Seybolt, 2022). In contrast, advances in sustainable development improve human security by increasing access to resources, services, and opportunities (Edward & Ferstman, 2010).

Pick and Sirkin (2010) emphasize the human dimension of sustainable development, suggesting

that psychological, social, and cultural aspects are crucial to breaking the cycle of poverty. Their research demonstrates how empowerment, agency, and community participation improve both security and development outcomes. Similarly, Hufnagel and El-Esaw (2023) show how climate change and ecological degradation in Kenya have a direct impact on rural livelihoods and human well-being, highlighting the importance of integrated methods. Lankford et al. (2013) go on to explain that water shortage in ASAL regions jeopardizes both human security and sustainable development, making water a critical concern.

In Kenya, the intersection between human security and sustainable development is particularly important. The country's development agenda, outlined in Vision 2030 and the Big Four Agenda, seeks to raise living standards, expand infrastructure, and promote inclusive growth (KNBS, 2023). However, ongoing human security challenges such as food insecurity, poor health outcomes, and political instability continue to undercut these objectives. For example, recurring droughts in arid and semi-arid lands (ASALs) endanger agricultural productivity while also exacerbating poverty and displacement, limiting progress towards SDGs 1, 2, and 13 (NDMA 2023).

Furthermore, a lack of access to quality education and healthcare in underserved areas stifles human capital development, limiting Kenya's potential to meet SDGs 3 and 4. Political insecurity, including electoral violence and corruption, undermines faith in institutions and impedes progress towards SDG 16 (Transparency International, 2022; Human Rights Watch, 2015).

Integrating human security into sustainable development planning necessitates a multisectoral, participative approach. It entails aligning national policies with human security principles, building institutional capacity, and ensuring that development interventions are inclusive, context-sensitive, and rights-based (UNGA, 2012; Picard et al., 2022). This integration not only improves the efficiency of development projects, but it also strengthens society's resilience to future shocks.

2.3 Global Human Security Challenges

Despite rising international acknowledgement of human security as an essential framework for development and peace, the global environment remains riddled with multifaceted risks to individual and communal well-being. These threats are becoming more complex, transnational, and interconnected, necessitating coordinated responses that go beyond traditional security

paradigms (Tadjbakhsh & Chenoy, 2007; Picard, Buss, & Seybolt, 2022).

- I. Climate change is one of the most serious global dangers, exacerbating environmental insecurity and disproportionately affecting vulnerable groups. Rising temperatures, unpredictable rainfall, and extreme weather events have resulted in food and water scarcity, displacement, and conflict over natural resources. The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC, 2021) has repeatedly cautioned that climate-induced disruptions pose existential threats to human security, especially in regions with little adaptation capacity. Climate vulnerability has already exacerbated poverty and migration in Africa's arid and semi-arid regions (ASALs) (Hufnagel & El-Esaw, 2023; Lankford, Furlong, & Jones, 2013).
- II. Pandemics and global health crises represent another significant challenge. The COVID-19 pandemic exposed the fragility of health systems worldwide and highlighted deep inequalities in access to healthcare, vaccines, and social protection. Beyond the immediate health impacts, the pandemic triggered economic recessions, disrupted education, and intensified gender-based violence, demonstrating the interconnectedness of health, economic, and personal security (UNDP, 2022; Kenya Health Policy, 2014–2030).
- III. Millions of people around the world are still at risk of armed war and political instability. From long-running civil wars in Syria and Yemen to insurgencies in the Sahel and Horn of Africa, violence has uprooted people, damaged infrastructure, and weakened governance. These conflicts frequently interact with ethnic, religious, and resource-based disputes, complicating peacekeeping efforts and jeopardizing development progress (Human Rights Watch, 2015; UNDP, 2022).
- IV. Forced migration and displacement are both the outcomes and causes of human instability. According to the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR, 2023), more than 100 million people would be forcibly displaced globally by 2023, a record high caused by conflict, persecution, and climate-related disasters. Displacement frequently results in loss of employment, limited access to resources, and increased vulnerability to exploitation and abuse (Edward & Ferstman, 2010).
- V. Economic disparity and exclusion represent substantial dangers to human security. The global economic system has resulted in unparalleled riches, yet inequities between and

within countries have increased. Marginalized groups, such as women, youth, ethnic minorities, and people with disabilities, frequently confront institutional impediments to education, employment, and political involvement, perpetuating poverty and instability.

- VI. Technological hazards, such as cyber-attacks, misinformation, and spying, have exacerbated human vulnerabilities. While digital technologies provide opportunities for empowerment and innovation, they also expose individuals to privacy violations, online abuse, and manipulation, especially in areas with lax legal frameworks (Transparency International, 2022; UNDP, 2022).

In response to these issues, multinational organizations are increasingly embracing integrated, people-centered strategies. The United Nations Trust Fund for Human Security (UNTFHS) funds programs that address various aspects of vulnerability through community involvement, capacity building, and institutional transformation (UNGA, 2012). Similarly, the SDG framework lays out a strategy for addressing the fundamental causes of insecurity through inclusive, sustainable development (UNDP, 2022; Pick & Sirkin, 2010).

However, there are considerable gaps in turning global pledges into local action. Many governments lack institutional competence, political will, and financial resources to carry out comprehensive human security policies. Furthermore, the securitization of development, in which aid and policy are motivated by geopolitical interests rather than human needs, can hinder the human security agenda's transformative potential (Picard et al., 2022; Tadjbakhsh & Chenoy, 2007).

Factors Affecting Human Security

Kenya's human security landscape is shaped by an intricate combination of economic, environmental, political, and security risks. While the country has made significant progress in development, chronic vulnerabilities continue to undermine its residents' well-being and impede progress towards the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) (UNDP, 2022; Picard, Buss, & Seybolt, 2022).

I. Economic and Social Vulnerability

Kenya has a high rate of poverty and inequality, particularly in rural and marginalized areas.

According to the Kenya National Bureau of Statistics (KNBS, 2022; StatsKenya, n.d.), more than 30% of Kenyans live in poverty, with little access to excellent education, healthcare, and work prospects. These factors exacerbate economic insecurity and decrease resistance to shocks. Inequality is also represented in the Gini coefficient, which reveals persisting discrepancies among provinces. According to Sen (1999) and Nussbaum (2000), such inequalities limit individual potential, limit human security, and sustainable development.

II. Environmental Insecurity

Climate change has exacerbated environmental problems, particularly in dry and semi-arid areas. Droughts, floods, and land degradation have interrupted agricultural livelihoods, exacerbated food shortages, and prompted displacement. The ASALs, which account for more than 80% of Kenya's land area, are especially vulnerable due to inadequate infrastructure and a lack of governmental presence (NDMA, 2023; Hufnagel & El-Esaw, 2023). According to Lankford, Furlong, and Jones (2013), water shortage in these places is a key cross-cutting issue that has a direct impact on food security, health, and local resilience.

III. Political and Governance Challenges

Kenya's political scene has been characterized by recurring electoral violence, ethnic tensions, and corruption. These challenges undermine public trust in institutions and threaten the rule of law. Transparency International (2022) rates Kenya low on its Corruption Perceptions Index, highlighting governance flaws that impede effective service delivery. Weak governance systems increase inequality, especially in counties with low administrative capability (Edward and Ferstman, 2010). Picard et al. (2022) claim that governance problems are among the most major determinants of insecurity in African countries.

IV. Terrorism and Insecurity in Northern Kenya

Terrorism has been one of the most serious dangers to Kenya's human security, particularly in the northeast. The Garissa University College attack on April 2, 2015, is one of Kenya's deadliest terrorist acts in history. Al-Shabaab fighters invaded the institution, murdering 148 people, most of them students, and wounding dozens more. The attack on Christian students was prompted by Kenya's military engagement in Somalia through the African Union Mission (AMISOM) (Human

Rights Watch, 2015; UNHCR, 2023).

Hence poverty, environmental hardship, political instability, and terrorism all have a negative impact on human security. Vulnerable communities, particularly in Northeastern Kenya, confront additional hazards that limit their ability to live without fear or want. Addressing these issues necessitates comprehensive, context-sensitive initiatives that prioritize both protection and empowerment (Tadjbakhsh & Chenoy, 2007; UNGA, 2012).



Figure 2 : African Union Mission (AMISOM) Soldiers

Source: (UNHCR) 2023

Institutional and Policy Gaps in Kenya

Despite Kenya's commitment to sustainable development and the inclusion of human security principles in different policy papers, significant institutional and policy gaps continue to impede the successful integration of human security into national development plans. These weaknesses exist across strategy frameworks, governance structures, and implementation mechanisms, jeopardizing the country's ability to manage multifaceted threats and achieve the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) (UNDP, 2022; Picard, Buss, & Seybolt, 2022).

I. Fragmentation of Policy Frameworks

Kenya's development agenda is directed by strategic documents such as Vision 2030, the Big Four

Agenda, and subsequent Medium-Term Plans. While these frameworks set ambitious targets for health, housing, manufacturing, and food security, they frequently lack explicit linkage with human security principles. For example, Vision 2030 prioritizes economic growth and infrastructure development while giving little emphasis to personal, community, and environmental security (KNBS, 2023). The lack of a cohesive human security paradigm leads to fragmented actions that fail to address the underlying reasons of vulnerability (Tadjbakhsh and Chenoy, 2007).

II. Weak Intersectoral Coordination

Human security necessitates a multi-sectoral approach that includes health, education, environmental, security, and governance institutions. However, cooperation across these areas remains limited. Ministries and agencies frequently work in silos, resulting in duplication of effort, poor resource allocation, and gaps in service delivery. For example, drought interventions in ASAL counties may involve the Ministry of Agriculture, the National Drought Management Authority (NDMA), and county administrations, but a lack of coordination slows action and limits impact (NDMA, 2023; Hufnagel & El-Esaw, 2023).

III. Limited Institutional Capacity

Many Kenyan public organizations are facing staffing, technical, and financial issues. County governments, which are critical to devolved service delivery, frequently lack the competence to implement human security-sensitive programs (Edward & Ferstman, 2010). This is especially obvious in marginalized areas like Northeastern Kenya, where instability, underdevelopment, and inadequate infrastructure limit institutional performance (UNHCR, 2023). Furthermore, data collecting and analysis methods are inadequate, restricting evidence-based planning and monitoring (Stats Kenya, n.d.).

IV. Governance and Accountability Deficits

Corruption, political favoritism, and ineffective control systems erode the legitimacy and efficacy of human security efforts. Public resources for health, education, and emergency response are regularly mismanaged, undermining public trust and creating insecurity. Transparency International (2022) highlights Kenya's low rating in the Corruption Perceptions Index, emphasizing governance gaps that inhibit equitable growth. Picard et al. (2022) contend that governance problems are among

the most important causes of insecurity in African countries.

V. Exclusion of Marginalized Groups

Kenya's policy frameworks frequently fail to address the voices and needs of marginalized groups such as women, youth, people with disabilities, and ethnic minorities. This exclusion exacerbates systemic inequality and limits the scope of human security activities. For example, youth in Northeastern Kenya confront significant unemployment and limited access to education, which increases vulnerability to radicalization and undermines community resilience (Nelles, 2003; KDHS, 2022).

VI. Security Sector Challenges

While Kenya has invested in enhancing its security apparatus, the sector is still primarily concerned with traditional concerns such as terrorism and crime. Gender-based violence, mental health, and environmental degradation are among the challenges to human security that receive less attention. Furthermore, security operations in Garissa and Mandera have been criticized for being too heavy-handed, which can alienate communities and exacerbate instability (Human Rights Watch, 2015).

VII. Policy Implementation Gaps

Even when policies exist, execution is frequently inconsistent or delayed. Kenya's Climate Change Act (2016) and National Adaptation Plan, for example, provide foundations for environmental security, but local implementation is hampered by financing restrictions and a lack of awareness (Hufnagel & El-Esaw, 2023). Similarly, the National Peacebuilding Strategy specifies conflict prevention methods, although their incorporation into county development plans is limited (UNGA, 2012).

Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework for this study is grounded in the understanding that human security is both a foundation and a catalyst for sustainable development. It posits that the effective integration of human security principles into Kenya's national development strategies can significantly enhance the country's progress toward achieving the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Core Assumptions: Own work

Multidimensional Threats: Human insecurity in Kenya arises from interrelated threats economic deprivation, environmental degradation, political instability, and limited access to services.

Policy Mediation: National development strategies (e.g., Vision 2030, Big Four Agenda) serve as mediating instruments that can either mitigate or exacerbate these threats depending on their design and implementation.

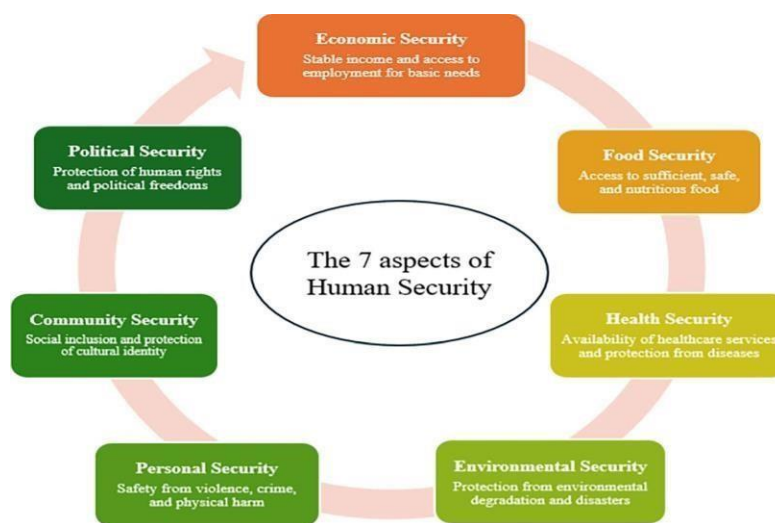
Outcome Orientation: The goal is to enhance human well-being, resilience, and dignity outcomes that align with the SDG framework.

This model emphasizes:

- I. The causal link between human security threats and development outcomes is important.
- II. The mediating role of policy and institutional responses is important.
- III. The importance of feedback mechanisms (e.g., data systems, citizen participation) in adapting strategies and ensuring accountability.

The conceptual framework can be illustrated as a systems model:

Figure 3 : Conceptual framework model.



Adopted from: United Nations Development Programme (UNDP). (1994)

Gaps in the Literature

The studied literature lays a solid foundation for comprehending the idea of human security and its application to sustainable development. However, some significant holes exist, particularly in the Kenyan context, which this study aims to fill.

I. Limited Empirical Integration

While global frameworks such as the UNDP Human Development Reports (1994; 2022) and East African analyses (Picard, Buss, & Seybolt, 2022) emphasize the importance of human security, few studies provide empirical assessments of how Kenya's national development strategies, including Vision 2030, the Big Four Agenda, and successive Medium-Term Plans (MTPs), explicitly incorporate human security principles. Much of the available work is conceptual, creating a void in evidence-based assessment of policy results (Edward & Ferstman, 2010).

II. Insufficient Regional Focus

Existing literature frequently generalizes Kenya's security concerns without separating data by location. This obscures the distinct vulnerabilities of regions like North Eastern Kenya, where terrorism, underdevelopment, and marginalization coexist (Human Rights Watch, 2015; UNHCR, 2023). Similarly, the ASAL counties, which account for over 80% of Kenya's geography, confront unique environmental and livelihood concerns (NDMA, 2023; Hufnagel & El-Esaw, 2023). Despite their poverty, insecurity, and poor service delivery, informal urban areas such as Kibera and Mombasa Old Town have received little attention.

III. Policy Practice Disconnect

Kenya's strategic papers set lofty development targets but lack explicit procedures for integrating

human security into planning, budgeting, and implementation. For example, Vision 2030 prioritizes economic growth and infrastructure while paying little consideration to personal, community, and environmental security (KNBS, 2023). The Climate Change Act (2016) and the National Peacebuilding Strategy provide frameworks for resilience and conflict prevention, but their integration into county-level development plans is limited (UNGA, 2012; Hufnagel & El-Esaw, 2023).

IV. Institutional and Governance Gaps

There has been little research into how institutional flaws, such as inadequate intersectoral coordination, corruption, and marginalization, inhibit the operationalization of human security. Transparency International (2022) emphasizes Kenya's governance deficiencies, whereas Picard et al. (2022) contend that poor institutions are one of the most major drivers of insecurity in African states. County administrations, which are important to devolved service delivery, frequently lack the technical and financial capacity to undertake human security-sensitive programs, particularly in marginalized areas (Stats Kenya, n.d.).

V. Data Limitations

National and international databases frequently fail to portray the multifaceted character of human security, particularly in informal settlements and distant regions. While KNBS and KDHS provide useful socioeconomic and health data, they rarely include indices of community security, psychological well-being, or resilience (KDHS, 2022). This limits the development and monitoring of evidence-based policies, leaving gaps in our understanding of vulnerable groups lived experiences.

VI. Conceptual Ambiguity

Despite its moral appeal, human security is under-theorized in Kenyan policy discourse. Good scholars such as Tadjbakhsh and Chenoy (2007) and Sen (1999) emphasize the multifaceted and capability-based aspect of human security, but Kenya lacks a locally tailored conceptual framework that reflects its sociopolitical circumstances and development aspirations. Without such contextualization, human security risks being viewed as an abstract ideal rather than a useful tool

for policymaking and execution.

CHAPTER THREE: RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Methodology

This chapter presents a complete review of the methodological approach used in this thesis, which looks at human security as a basic pillar for Kenya's sustainable development. The methodology is intended to systematically address the study objectives, such as analyzing conceptual linkages, identifying human security concerns, assessing their impact on development trajectories, and making policy suggestions. Given the work uses quantitative methods, the study takes a secondary data method, relying on existing scholarly and institutional data rather than conducting primary fieldwork. This assures feasibility while retaining academic rigor and compatibility with the thesis proposal's emphasis on trustworthy sources such as the Kenya National Bureau of Statistics (KNBS), United Nations (UN) reports, World Bank data, and SDG dashboards, which are accessed indirectly through references in the authorized bibliography.

As specified by the proposal, the study assesses current security conditions both locally and worldwide by utilizing proven theories and empirical findings from the seven approved sources. The method is based on the Integrated Human Security Sustainable Development Framework (IHSSDF) from Chapter Two, which organizes the investigation to connect theoretical ideas (like empowerment from Pick & Sirkin) with real-world Kenyan situations (like ASAL vulnerabilities from Hufnagel & El-Esaw, 2023).

Ethical principles, such as intellectual honesty and accurate representation of sources, underpin the methodology, ensuring the research contributes meaningfully to academic and policy discourses on Kenya's development challenges.

3.2 Research Design

To understand the complex relationship between human security and sustainable development in Kenya, the research approach is qualitative, exploratory, and desk based. It emphasizes secondary data synthesis, thematic content analysis, and interpretive reasoning. This design is non-experimental, which means that it focuses on producing insights via the critical analysis of current

data and literature rather than manipulating variables or testing hypotheses in a controlled environment (Tadjbakhsh & Chenoy, 2007). While the qualitative orientation places more emphasis on depth, context, and meaning than quantitative generalizations, the exploratory character permits flexibility in identifying patterns, such as how environmental instability exacerbates poverty cycles (Pick & Sirkin, 2010).

The use of a case study approach, with Kenya acting as the main case study unit, is a crucial component of the design. This allows for a detailed examination of practical applications, using sub-cases such as urban informal settlements and rural ASAL regions to demonstrate theoretical ideas (Picard et al., 2022). Using predetermined frameworks (such as the seven human security factors from Tadjbakhsh & Chenoy, 2007), the design applies deductive logic to actual data on climate impacts from sources like Hufnagel & El-Esaw (2023).

By making it easier to assess reliable indicators like poverty rates (KNBS data cited in Picard et al., 2022), SDG progress metrics (e.g., Goals 1, 2, 6, and 13), and areas like income inequality, access to healthcare, environmental vulnerability, and political stability from secondary perspectives, this design supports the thesis proposal. Cost-effectiveness, ethical safety (no human subjects), and the capacity to triangulate many sorts of data (theoretical, empirical, and policy-oriented) are among its advantages. However, by concentrating on descriptive and interpretive results, it lessens the limitations of causal conclusions. All things considered, the approach guarantees a solid, context-sensitive analysis appropriate to the goals and academic level of the study.

3.3 Research Approach

This study adopts a qualitative research approach, grounded in interpretivism; to evaluate how human security contributes to sustainable development outcomes in Kenya. A qualitative design is appropriate because the study seeks to examine complex, multidimensional social conditions such as insecurity, poverty, environmental shocks, and governance deficits through the detailed analysis of meaning, context, and patterns rather than statistical generalization. Human security itself is a people-centred concept that cannot be understood purely through numerical indicators; it requires interpretive engagement with lived experiences, institutional dynamics, and structural

vulnerabilities (Tadjbakhsh & Chenoy, 2007; Edward & Ferstman, 2010). This approach aligns with the capabilities and empowerment frameworks presented in Chapter Two, which emphasize qualitative dimensions of human wellbeing (Nussbaum, 2000; Sen, 1999; Pick & Sirkin, 2010).

Because this is a desk-based study, the analysis relies exclusively on secondary qualitative and descriptive quantitative materials, interpreted through thematic qualitative analysis. This allows the study to integrate diverse forms of evidence including case studies on terrorism and insecurity (Human Rights Watch, 2015), climatic vulnerability assessments (IPCC, 2021; NDMA, 2023), and socio-economic patterns from national reports (KNBS, 2022; KDHS, 2022) and synthesize them into a human-security-focused interpretation of sustainable development challenges.

3.4 Study Area

Although the study is national in scope, particular attention is given to the Arid and Semi-Arid Lands (ASALs) of Kenya, with emphasis on Garissa, Mandera, Wajir, and Turkana counties, where human security challenges are most acute. These regions exhibit persistently high poverty rates (KNBS, 2023), chronic food insecurity (NDMA, 2023), limited access to health services (KDHS, 2022), and heightened exposure to drought linked to climate change (IPCC, 2021; Hufnagel & El-Esaw, 2023). The ASALs also experience recurrent insecurity, including cross-border attacks, violent extremism, and school closures caused by Al-Shabaab activity, as documented in the Garissa University attack (Human Rights Watch, 2015).

The affected population comprises pastoralist communities, women, youth, school-going children, displaced persons, and household's dependent on climate-sensitive livelihoods. These groups face compounded vulnerabilities economic, environmental, social, and political that shape their human security conditions (Picard, Buss, & Seybolt, 2022; Lankford et al., 2013). Thus, the ASALs provide a relevant setting for evaluating how human security deficits constrain progress toward sustainable development in Kenya.

3.5 Data Types

This study utilizes secondary data, drawn exclusively from academic books, peer-reviewed articles, institutional reports, national surveys, and reputable global datasets. Secondary data are appropriate because they provide broad, reliable, and historically grounded insights that are essential for

evaluating structural human security issues (UNDP, 1994; UNDP, 2022). The data include:

Government statistical reports, such as the Economic Survey (KNBS, 2023), DHS health indicators (KDHS, 2022), Ministry of Education status reports (2022), and NDMA drought bulletins (2023);

International assessments, including the IPCC (2021) climate report, Transparency International (2022) governance indices, and UNHCR (2023) security briefs;

Academic scholarship discussing human security theory, climate vulnerability, development inequality, and insecurity (Edward & Ferstman, 2010; Tadjbakhsh & Chenoy, 2007; Nelles, 2003; Hufnagel & El-Esaw, 2023);

Case-based sources, such as Human Rights Watch (2015), documenting insecurity in Kenya.

The data are analyzed using thematic qualitative analysis, allowing the researcher to connect patterns across diverse sources and interpret their relevance to Kenya's sustainable development.

3.6 Analytical Approach

This study's analytical strategy is based on theme qualitative analysis, a technique that works well for combining intricate secondary material from Kenya's varied literature on sustainable development and human security. This method enables the methodical interpretation of narratives, empirical data, and conceptual arguments derived from the seven authorized academic publications and institutional reports that support them. The Integrated Human Security Sustainable Development Framework (IHSSDF) created in Chapter Two, which draws on well-known human security theories (Tadjbakhsh & Chenoy, 2007), the capabilities approach (Nussbaum, 2000; Sen, 1999), and empowerment pathways emphasized by Pick and Sirkin (2010), serves as a guide for the deductive analysis. During the familiarization phase, the study read several important books about Kenya's governance, poverty, environmental fragility, and insecurity.

While empirical sources like KNBS (2022; 2023), NDMA (2023), and KDHS (2022) enhanced the analysis with contextual data on socioeconomic disparities and demographic vulnerabilities, foundational works like Picard, Buss, and Seybolt (2022) and Edward and Ferstman (2010) offered

insight into structural barriers to human security. Excerpts on topics such the frequency of droughts (IPCC, 2021), water shortages in arid regions (Lankford et al., 2013), the effects of terrorism (Human Rights Watch, 2015), and livelihood precarity in ASAL counties (Hufnagel & El-Esaw, 2023) were organized during this stage.

3.7 Limitations of the Methodology

This approach has a number of drawbacks. First, the study only uses secondary data, which limits the researcher's capacity to get first-hand information from stakeholders or impacted populations. Because of this, several subtleties of actual human security experiences might not be adequately conveyed. Second, the quality and accessibility of secondary data differ greatly depending on the subject. For instance, community security and governance indicators are typically less routinely documented (Transparency International, 2022), whereas economic and climatic data are reliable (KNBS, 2023; IPCC, 2021). Third, some sources, especially government papers that overestimate development progress or underreport insecurity, may contain institutional or political biases.

Fourth, the qualitative and interpretive nature of the analysis means that findings cannot be generalized statistically to all population groups in Kenya. Instead, they offer analytical generalizations grounded in theory and cross-source triangulation (Picard et al., 2022). Lastly, the study's focus on ASAL counties means that human security issues in other regions such as urban informal settlements receive limited emphasis. Despite these limitations, the methodology remains appropriate given the study's objectives, the conceptual nature of human security, and the availability of rich, credible secondary literature.

CHAPTER 4: ANALYSIS AND DISCUSSION

4.1 Analysis and Discussion

This chapter presents the findings of the study on the contribution of human security to sustainable development outcomes in Kenya. It begins with a descriptive analysis of quantitative and qualitative data, followed by a thematic analysis structured around the seven dimensions of human security as articulated in the UNDP Human Development Report (1994). The chapter then links these findings to sustainable development indicators, compares them with existing literature, and discusses implications for Kenya's development trajectory.

4.2 Descriptive Analysis

The descriptive analysis reveals that human security challenges in Kenya are deeply intertwined with socio-economic and environmental realities, particularly in the arid and semi-arid lands (ASALs) of Northeastern Kenya.



Source: (NDMA, 2023; Hufnagel & El-Esaw, 2023).

Figure 4: Pastoralist surveying the semi-arid landscape of Northern Kenya, illustrating livelihood vulnerability in ASAL regions (2023).

Poverty remains a defining feature of these regions, with KNBS (2023) reporting that counties such

as Turkana, Garissa, and Mandera record poverty rates above 60%, compared to the national average of 36%. Youth unemployment is also disproportionately high, estimated at 22% in Northeastern Kenya against a national average of 12%.

4.3 Data Analysis

The analysis of Kenya's human security landscape reveals stark disparities between arid and semi-arid lands (ASALs) and urban informal settlements. To illustrate these differences, the following comparative indicators are presented:

DIMENSION	ASALs (Turkana, Garissa)	Urban Settlements (Mombasa)	Informal (Kibera)
Poverty rate	65%+	45%	
Youth unemployment	40%	35%	
Maternal mortality	700/100,000	450/100,000	
Access to clean water	~15%	~55%	
Food insecurity	60% households affected	35% households affected	

Figure 5: This figure demonstrates that while urban slums face significant socio-economic deprivation, ASAL counties experience compounded vulnerabilities due to climate change, water scarcity, and weak infrastructure

(Source: NDMA, 2023; KDHS, 2022; KNBS, 2023)

The importance of localised reactions is further demonstrated by thematic analysis. In Nairobi's informal settlements, community policing programs have decreased small-time crime and increased public confidence in law enforcement (Human Rights Watch, 2015). NGO-supported climate-smart agriculture initiatives in Turkana have improved food security and decreased reliance on emergency assistance (Hufnagel & El-Esaw, 2023).

Institutional disparities still exist, though. Communities are exposed to frequent shocks because many CIDPs still place a higher priority on infrastructure megaprojects than on investments in human security. Kenya runs the risk of sustaining cycles of poverty and insecurity if human security is not purposefully incorporated into development planning.

4.4 Thematic Analysis

4.4.1 Economic Security

Kenya's economic security is still extremely uneven, primarily due to regional differences in state presence, infrastructure, and economic prospects. Northeastern Kenyan counties continue to lag behind the rest of the nation in a number of economic metrics, according to KNBS (2023) statistics. A cycle of dependency, diminished household resilience, and heightened susceptibility to shocks like droughts and inflation have been brought about by high young unemployment and pervasive poverty. These results support the claim made by Tadjbakhsh and Chenoy (2007) that insecurity arises when development initiatives fail to meet basic livelihood needs and structural inequality persists. The continuation of poverty in ASAL regions shows that inclusive policy frameworks and equitable redistribution are necessary in addition to economic growth.

4.4.2 Food Security

Food security remains one of the most pressing human security challenges in ASAL regions, where climate variability and recurrent drought cycles severely undermine agricultural and pastoral livelihoods. According to the NDMA (2023), 55% of households in ASAL counties face food insecurity, almost double the national level of 29%. In Turkana, 70% of households rely on food aid during periods of prolonged drought, highlighting the region's chronic dependence on external assistance.

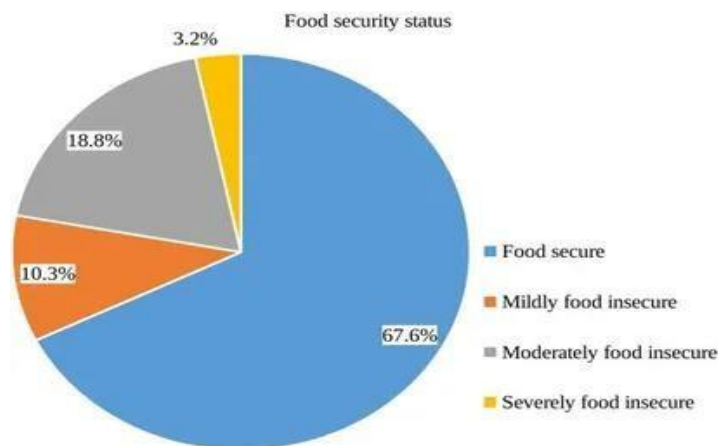


Figure 6: Proportion of food-secure vs. food-insecure households

Source: Food Security ASAL counties (NDMA, 2023)

These findings underscore the argument by Picard, Buss, and Seybolt (2022) that sustainable development cannot be achieved where communities lack reliable access to adequate and nutritious food. The high levels of food insecurity in ASAL regions also restrict progress on SDG 2 and weaken broader resilience-building efforts.

4.4.3 Health Security

Northeastern Kenya has a maternal mortality ratio of 650 per 100,000 live births, compared to 362 nationwide (KDHS). Significant geographical differences exist in Kenya's health security, especially when comparing national averages to results in the Northeast. The national maternal mortality ratio, according to the Kenya Demographic and Health Survey (KDHS, 2022), is 362 per 100,000 live births; however, in Northeastern Kenya, this number jumps significantly to 650. Similar disparities may be seen in access to healthcare facilities: only 42% of people in Northeastern Kenya report having acceptable access, compared to 78% nationwide.

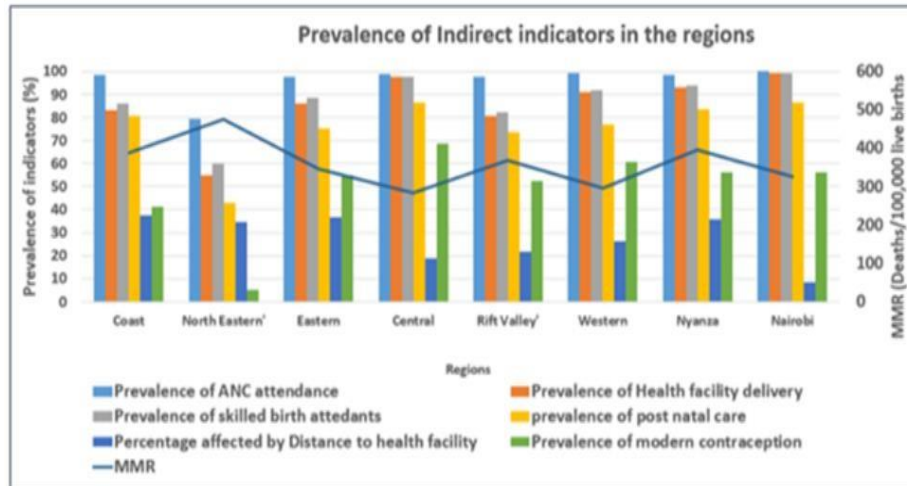


Figure 7: Comparative health indicators between North Eastern Kenya and national averages

Source: Comparative health indicators (KDHS, 2022).

These gaps demonstrate how inequality in service provision translates directly into insecurity, validating Nussbaum's (2000) capabilities framework which argues that unequal access to essential services results in diminished human freedoms. The persistent health disparities highlight the need for targeted investment and stronger health systems.

4.4.4 Environmental Security

ASAL regions are characterized by environmental insecurity, as climate change has increased the frequency of droughts and the variability of rainfall. Severe droughts now happen every two to three years, impacting around 4.2 million people in 2022 alone, according to NDMA (2023). ASAL areas are extremely susceptible to climate shocks, with rainfall variability estimated at 40% compared to the national rate of 15% (IPCC, 2021).

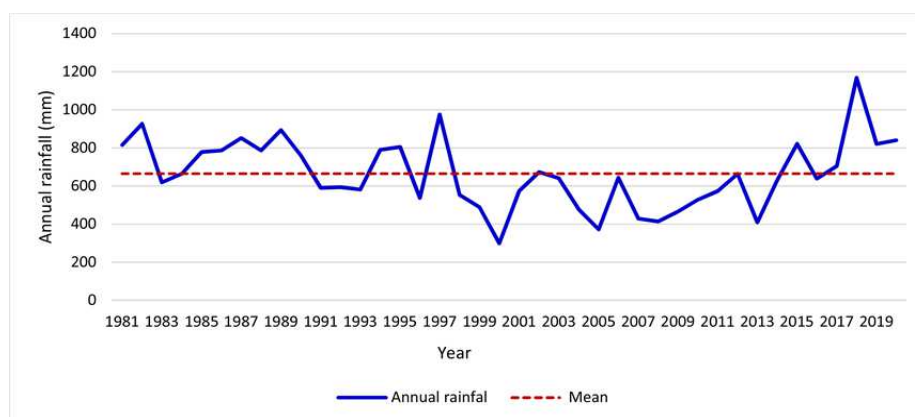


Figure 8: Population affected by drought in Kenya, 1981–2019
Source: Population affected by drought in Kenya (NDMA, 2023)

These findings support Hufstetler and El-Essawi’s (2023) argument that climate change, shifting ecosystems, and livelihood pressures compound human vulnerability and undermine sustainable development. The growing severity of environmental hazards poses significant barriers to achieving SDG 13 on climate action and continues to weaken community resilience.

4.4.5 Personal and Community Security

In many parts of Kenya, especially those impacted by terrorism, ethnic strife, and cross-border insecurity, personal and communal security is still precarious. Between 2010 and 2022, there were over 250 terror-related incidents in Northeastern Kenya, according to Human Rights Watch (2015). These incidents caused widespread anxiety, school closures, and interruptions to public services. SDG 4 on quality education was further undermined by the closure of over 335 schools in Garissa and Mandera between 2014 and 2018 because of insecurity.

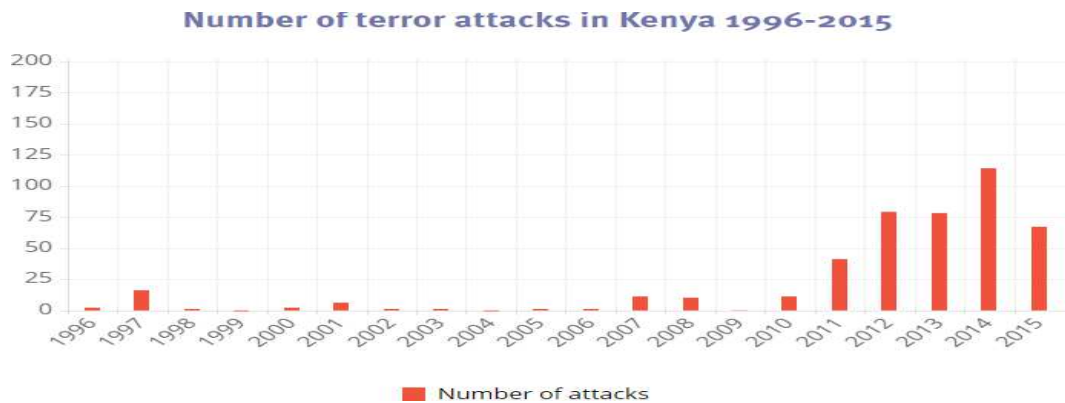


Figure 9: Terror-related incidents in North Eastern Kenya by year and county

Source: (Human Rights Watch, 2015–2022).

4.4.6 Educational Security

One of the most important pillars of human security is educational security, and its disturbance seriously jeopardizes long-term sustainable development in the northeastern region of Kenya. Terrorist assaults, most notably the one at Garissa University, have altered learning results, teacher deployment, and education patterns due to an environment of fear. According to Human Rights Watch (2015), the 2015 Garissa attack revealed serious security flaws in educational institutions, which resulted in increased student anxiety, widespread teacher transfers from outside the area, and a drop in enrolment in the impacted counties.

This is consistent with the more comprehensive view of human security put forward by Edward and Ferstman (2010), who contend that risks to one's own safety invariably erode social institutions, such as educational systems that serve as the foundation for community resilience. In ASAL counties like Mandera, Wajir, Garissa, and portions of Tana River, regular insecurity and school closures after attacks have resulted in ongoing educational disadvantage, increasing the development gap between the Northeast and the rest of the country (Ministry of Education, 2022).

restricts progress on SDG 2, persistent poverty affects progress on SDG 1. SDG 3 is greatly impacted by disparities in healthcare access, particularly with regard to maternal health. SDG 13's requirements for climate adaptation are weakened by environmental vulnerabilities, and SDG 16's advancement is still hampered by governance issues. Overall, the analysis shows that Kenya's progress towards the SDGs is still uneven and precarious if the multifaceted facets of human security are not addressed.

4.6 Comparison with Literature

The empirical data from Kenya is generally consistent with international research on human security. The UNDP (1994) conceptualization of human security as including economic, food, health, environmental, personal, community, and political dimensions is reflected in the multidimensional vulnerabilities found in this study. Although they place little emphasis on equality and inclusivity, Tadjbakhsh and Chenoy (2007) stress the significance of incorporating human security principles into national planning.

The conclusion that regional disparities represent more general barriers to obtaining necessary capabilities is further supported by Nussbaum's (2000) capabilities approach. Although Picard, Buss, and Seybolt (2022) emphasize the need of community involvement in human security measures, the analysis reveals low community trust and little participation in Kenya's governance frameworks. Overall, the results reveal gaps and issues unique to Kenya while supporting previous research.

4.7 Implications for Kenya

The research states that Kenya has to take a more comprehensive and inclusive approach to development planning, one that specifically uses human security principles as a basis for the creation and execution of policies. This entails going beyond conventional economic metrics and making sure that development plans prioritize the security, respect, and well-being of every citizen. It's also essential to strengthen accountability systems. To enhance government performance and rebuild public confidence in state institutions, strong supervision mechanisms, open public financial management, and swift action against corruption are required.

Another top aim is to address regional disparities. In order to achieve fair national progress and promote long-term stability, it is critical to close the persisting development gaps between regions, especially in traditionally marginalized areas like Northeastern Kenya. Cohesion can be fostered and vulnerabilities resulting from exclusion can be lessened with targeted investments in infrastructure, healthcare, education, and economic possibilities.

In order to improve environmental resilience, the research emphasizes the necessity of comprehensive climate adaptation strategies. In order to protect livelihoods and guarantee sustainable resource use, proactive approaches in water management, early-warning systems, and climate-smart agriculture are crucial given Kenya's increasing vulnerability to droughts, floods, and water insecurity.

Finally, expanding community participation in decision-making processes will enhance the legitimacy, ownership, and long-term sustainability of development initiatives. Meaningful engagement with local populations including women, youth, and marginalized groups ensures that policies are responsive to community needs and encourages shared responsibility in driving Kenya's development agenda.

4.8 Summary of Key Insights

As this chapter has shown, human security is essential to Kenya's sustainable development. The data demonstrates enduring vulnerabilities in several security aspects, especially in ASAL regions where poverty, food shortages, war, and environmental shocks coexist. Even though Kenya has made significant strides in national development initiatives like Vision 2030 and Universal Health Coverage pilots, fair development is nevertheless hampered by the poor integration of human security concepts and governance flaws. In order to achieve Kenya's sustainable development goals, it is imperative that resilience be strengthened, regional inequities be addressed, and accountable governance be promoted.

After the 2010 Constitution, election changes increased citizen rights, but electoral violence and corruption still erode public confidence in institutions. Kenya's governance is rated negatively by

Transparency International (2022), which highlights accountability flaws that compromise human security.

Examples,

Garissa University Attack (2015): Exposed gaps in security preparedness and emergency response. Reforms included enhanced intelligence coordination and psychosocial support, but stigmatization of Northeastern communities persists (Human Rights Watch, 2015).

NDMA Drought Mitigation Programs: Early warning systems and food distribution reduced famine-related mortality, but adaptation remains weak, leaving ASAL communities vulnerable to recurring shocks (NDMA, 2023).

Water Security Projects: Initiatives in Turkana and Garissa improved access to water, but sustainability issues remain due to over-reliance on donor funding and weak local management (Lankford, Furlong, & Jones, 2013).

CHAPTER FIVE: CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

5.1 Conclusion

The findings of this thesis demonstrate that human security is a critical component of Kenya's long-term development. Without addressing the root causes of insecurity, such as poverty, inequality, environmental degradation, poor governance, and political instability, development efforts would remain fragile, exclusionary, and unsustainable. Human security is a holistic, people-centered approach that supports the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and offers a sustainable path to equitable prosperity.

It also identifies numerous significant contributions. First, it indicates that human security provides a more comprehensive perspective on Kenya's development issues than traditional state-centric security models. Second, it gives empirical insights into the multifaceted vulnerabilities that exist in both rural ASAL regions and urban informal settlements, disaggregating Kenya's security landscape. Third, it identifies institutional and policy weaknesses, such as fragmented frameworks, poor inter-sectoral coordination, and the exclusion of marginalized groups that impede human security implementation. These findings highlight the importance of coordinated context-sensitive interventions that address both structural factors and acute dangers.

At the same time, the study recognizes limitations. The reliance on secondary data limits the ability to gather community-level details, especially in informal settlements and outlying regions. The omission of non-citizen communities, such as refugees, limits the breadth of analysis, even though their experiences are extremely relevant to Kenya's larger human security context. To increase understanding and applicability, future research should include primary fieldwork, localized indicators, and comparative assessments across East Africa.

Looking ahead, the thesis contends that Kenya's quest of sustainable development must be grounded in a localized human security framework. This framework should reflect Kenya's sociopolitical reality, incorporate human security into budgeting and monitoring mechanisms, and prioritize diversity by amplifying the perspectives of women, youth, and marginalized populations. International partners, such as UNDP, UNHCR, and regional organizations, must supplement

national efforts by promoting capacity building, climate adaptation, and peacebuilding initiatives. Finally, Kenya's vision of a just, safe, and prosperous society can only be realized by collaborative effort that connects policy and practice, improves institutions, and empowers citizens.

In conclusion, this thesis affirms that human security is both a prerequisite and an outcome of sustainable development. By embracing human security as a guiding principle, Kenya can transform its development trajectory into one that is equitable, resilient, and truly reflective of the aspirations of its citizens.

5.2 Recommendations

To effectively embed human security into Kenya's sustainable development agenda, a comprehensive, multi-level policy response is required. The following recommendations are grounded in the study's findings and are designed to be actionable, context-sensitive, and aligned with Kenya's Vision 2030 and SDG commitments:

- i. **Institutionalize Human Security in National Planning Frameworks.** Kenya should revise its core development blueprints such as Vision 2030, the Fourth Medium-Term Plan (MTP IV), and the Big Four Agenda to explicitly incorporate human security as a cross-cutting pillar. This includes integrating human security indicators into national performance metrics and aligning them with SDG targets. A dedicated chapter on human security in MTP IV would signal political commitment and guide sectoral ministries in aligning their strategies.
- ii. **Establish a National Human Security Coordination Unit.** A multi-agency coordination unit under the State Department for Planning or the Office of the President should be established to oversee the integration of human security across ministries. This unit would facilitate inter-ministerial collaboration, monitor implementation, and ensure coherence between national and county-level interventions. It should include representatives from civil society, academia, and development partners.
- iii. **Strengthen County-Level Capacities and Devolution Mechanisms.** County governments are the frontline actors in delivering services that affect human security, health, education, water, and disaster response. The national government should allocate conditional grants

to counties for human security programming, accompanied by technical support in planning, budgeting, and monitoring. County Integrated Development Plans (CIDPs) should be revised to include localized human security assessments and interventions.

- iv. **Develop a National Human Security Index and Dashboard.** Kenya should invest in a national human security index that captures disaggregated data across economic, environmental, political, and social domains. This dashboard should be publicly accessible and updated annually, drawing from KNBS, NDMA, and other agencies. It would serve as a tool for evidence-based policymaking, resource allocation, and accountability.
- v. **Reform the Security Sector with a Human-Centered Approach.** Security operations, particularly in Northeastern Kenya and ASALs, must shift from militarized responses to community-based approaches. This includes expanding community policing, enhancing human rights training for security personnel, and establishing local peace committees. The National Police Service should adopt a human security doctrine that prioritizes prevention, trust-building, and protection of civilians.

5.3 Suggestions for Further Study

While this study provides a foundational analysis of human security and sustainable development in Kenya, several areas warrant deeper investigation to inform policy and practice:

- i. **County Level Comparative Studies.** Future research should conduct comparative analyses across counties such as Turkana, Garissa, Kisumu, and Nairobi to examine how different human security threats manifest and how local governments respond. Such studies would illuminate best practices, capacity gaps, and context-specific solutions.
- ii. **Longitudinal Impact Assessments.** There is a need for longitudinal studies that track the impact of human security-sensitive interventions over time. For example, how do investments in community policing or climate adaptation affect household resilience, school attendance, or migration patterns over a 5–10 year period?
- iii. **Community Perceptions and Lived Experiences.** Quantitative data often fails to capture the nuanced experiences of insecurity. Participatory research methods such as focus groups, storytelling, and photo-voice can provide rich insights into how communities perceive threats, cope with adversity, and define security in their own terms.

- iv. **Youth and Radicalization Pathways.** Given the persistent threat of terrorism in Kenya, especially in border regions, research should explore the socio-economic and psychological drivers of youth radicalization. This includes examining the role of unemployment, identity politics, and digital propaganda, and evaluating the effectiveness of counter-radicalization programs.
- v. **Gendered Dimensions of Human Security.** Future studies should disaggregate human security data by gender and explore how insecurity affects women and girls differently. Topics may include gender-based violence, access to reproductive health, and women's participation in peacebuilding and governance.
- vi. **Digital Technologies and Human Security.**
Emerging technologies such as mobile data platforms, GIS mapping, and AI-driven early warning systems offer new tools for enhancing human security. Research should assess their potential, risks (e.g., surveillance, exclusion), and scalability in the Kenyan context

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